More worryingly, extremist Buddhist groups are not just organising public demonstrations, but are also taking a growing degree of control over the country's educational system,[79] supplementing state schooling with Sunday schools. The textbooks they use are produced by the MaBaTha, the Organisation for the Protection of Race and Religion, a group that seeks to discriminate against other religions.

As Matthew Walton has noted, this points to the complexities of the situation especially in terms of how the Buddhists are perceived by the wider population. To many in Myanmar, such schools are important because of their Buddhist teaching rather than because they teach an anti-Islamic message. MaBaTha is, in principle, primarily focused on protecting Buddhism from what it sees as threats, and not all its senior members agree with the violently anti-Islamic message promoted by its leadership.[80] Nonetheless, the core message coming from these religiously inspired schools is not one of tolerance but one that seeks to claim that Buddhism is under threat from Islam.[81]

The MaBaTha, in conjunction with the 969 Movement, also runs 'buy Buddhist' campaigns to ensure that Muslim businesses are boycotted.[82] To promote this goal it has shifted politically to create a parliamentary alliance with the USDP so as to ensure discrimination is enshrined in legislation. The 'buy Buddhist' campaign has also gained state support[83] as the USDP is unwilling to upset an important part of its potential electorate.

This has spilled over into a campaign to close (mostly Muslim-run) slaughterhouses, which stems from fear that Muslims will eat all of the cows in Myanmar (thus harming agriculture). In Labutta (in northern Rakhine), under pressure from the MaBaTha, the local authorities first tried to prevent local farmers selling cows to some Muslim slaughterhouses, and then refused these slaughterhouses licences to operate. This hits both the economic livelihood of the Muslim community in the area and their religious practices. To the extremists, this is not an attack on Muslims as such, but on a critical way in which Muslim religious practice differs from what is acceptable within Buddhism: 'We are not deliberately targeting (Muslim) businesses. They would kill animals as they believe this is how they gain merit. That's the main difference between us and them'.[84] Naturally, some extremists go further and suggest that the Muslims only run slaughterhouses because 'They are practising how to cut our throats'.[85]